

Rightsizing Engagement Recap: What We Heard
October 5 - 12, 2026

Executive Summary

This memo is a weekly summary created by the Data & Accountability team to share public feedback on the proposed Rightsizing Scenarios. It covers community input gathered betwee**n October 5 and October 12, 2026.** These weekly reports exist to make the decision-making process open and transparent.

During the week of October 5–12, Portland Public Schools hosted two public engagement sessions:

- Board of Education Meeting | October 6th.
- Board of Education Community Connection | October 9th

Scenarios were released on October 5th, and presented to the public at the Board meeting on October 6th. A Rightsizing Community Survey was also released on October 5th. As of October 12th, 1,132 people have completed the Rightsizing Scenario Feedback Survey, representing every school community in the district. About 94% of respondents are connected to a school directly impacted by proposed closures, boundary changes, or program moves. Parents and guardians made up 73.8% of respondents.

Feedback from open-ended survey responses and community meetings focused on two primary areas:

1. **Support and Resources:** Families emphasize that safe transportation (district buses and crossing assistance on busy streets) is essential. Parents want students to stay with current classmates and teachers, and working families need guaranteed, affordable aftercare. Respondents also want equal facilities (air conditioning, modern technology, safe playgrounds), moving funds, and full-time counselors.
2. **Educational Equity:** Many respondents feel the plans place an unfair burden of closures and boundary changes on low-income and historically marginalized communities in East and Northeast Portland while protecting higher-income Westside schools. Some families express concern that moving Dual Language Immersion (DLI) programs causes language and racial segregation.

We also present common question themes emerging from community responses, including about school selection criteria, geographic equity, how students will get to school, information about financial transparency, staffing and specialized programs, and a desire for more information bout the enrollment forecasting process.

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Introduction

Every Monday, from when the rightsizing plans were released on October 5th until Superintendent Armstrong gives her recommendation to the board, the Data and Accountability team will gather and summarize public feedback. The purpose of these reports is to be open and clear. We want to share what community members have told us and explain how we will use that information. This memo shares what we have heard from our community between October 5 - 12, 2026.

Scenario Feedback Survey Findings

As of October 12th, we have received 1,132 responses from parents/guardians, PPS staff, students, and community members representing all of our school communities! About 94% of respondents represented school communities affected by the rightsizing scenario proposals in some way, including school closure, school consolidation, program changes, or boundary changes. See Tables 1-3 for a breakdown of respondent demographics, and see Appendix A for counts of responses by school to date.

Table 1:
Percentage of Respondents Representing Community Roles

Community Group	% Of Respondents
Parent/Guardian	73.84%
Student	2.35%
Staff/Educator	7.73%
Community Member	16.07%

Table 2:
Percentage of Respondents with Students Receiving Services

Services Received	% Of Respondents
Special Education	21.74%
Multilingual Learner Services	0.99%
Dual Language Immersion	13.48%
Talented and Gifted	20.84%
None of the above/Prefer not to say	42.95%

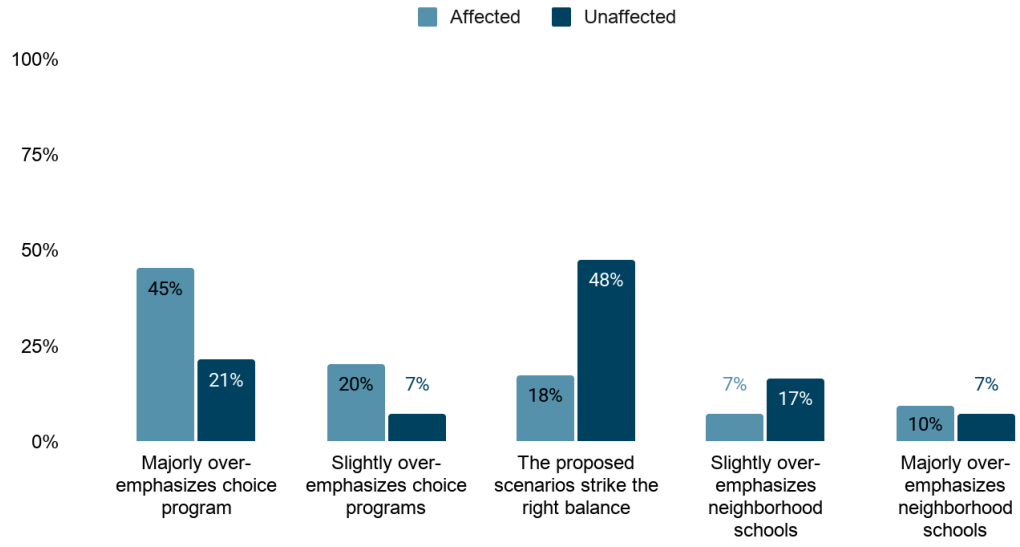
Table 3:
Percentage of Respondents by Race/Ethnicity

Race/Ethnicity of Respondents	% Of Respondents
Asian	4.22%
Black/African American	2.84%
Latino/a/e	6.01%
Native American	1.38%
NHPI	0.16%
White	64.01%
Multi-Racial	6.74%
Prefer Not to Say	14.62%

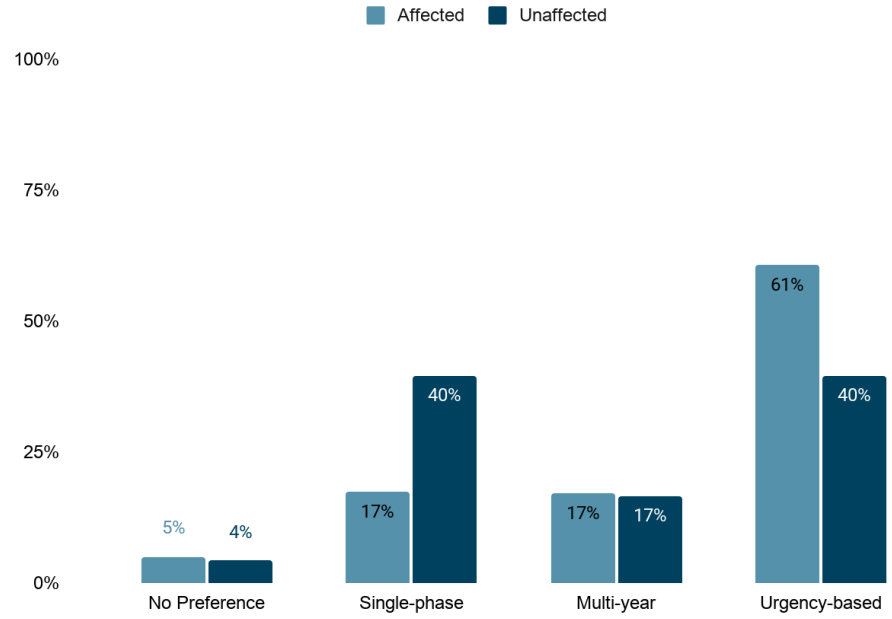
Close-Ended Response Analysis

Below, we present the results for close-ended questions regarding Rightsizing preferences, disaggregated by whether or not a respondent is directly affected by the proposed scenarios or not. Affected schools include any building facing a closure, a boundary change, or a programming change.

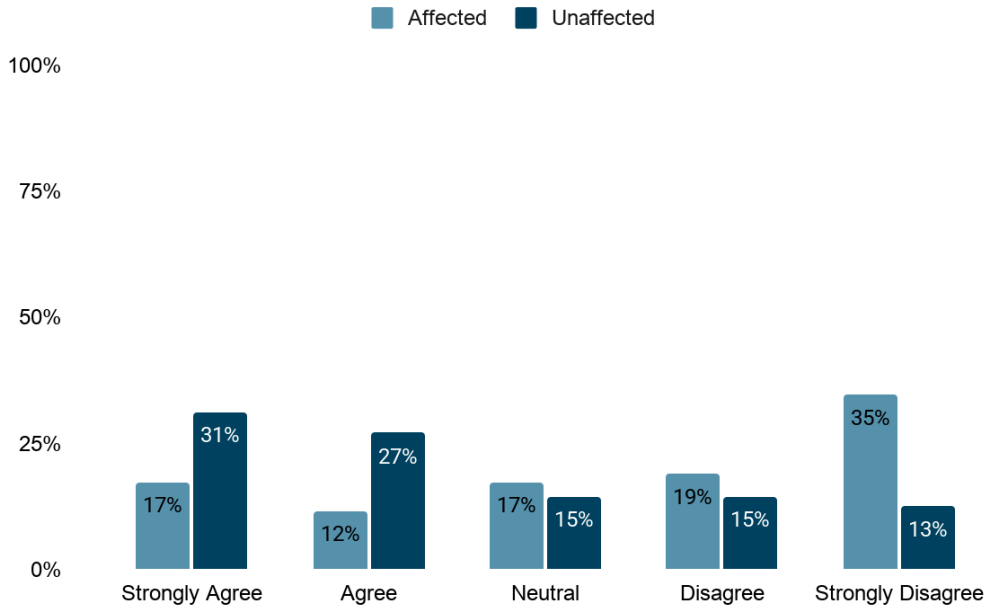
Resolution 7307 says that neighborhood schools are the foundation of the system when balancing access to choice programs. How well do the proposed scenarios balance those two needs?



Rightsizing involves a trade-off between how large changes are and how often they occur. Which approach best aligns with your priorities?



How much do you agree with this statement? "I am willing to accept a larger near-term adjustment (e.g., boundary change or closure) if it guarantees my school will not face further rightsizing for at least 5 years."



Open-Ended Response Analysis:
The survey asked the following open-ended questions:

- What specific support (e.g., transportation to school, students staying with their classmates) would you need if school changes occur all at once instead of over several years?
- What specific resources or help should the district provide to support schools affected by rightsizing?
- Our goal is to create a model that is fair and equitable to all communities. Did we miss any important equity issues, community history, or student needs in creating these models? If yes, please tell us what we missed and how we can address it.
- What is one thing you would like us to know about your school community?

Below, we present emerging findings from all open-ended questions across four themes: supports and resources, equity analysis, emerging themes, and emerging questions.

Supports and Resources
Community members say safe transportation is a must if school boundaries change or closures happen. Families need district busing, safe walking and biking routes, and crossing support at busy streets. Parents also want students to stay with their current classmates, friends, and trusted teachers to protect their emotional well-being. Additionally, working parents need expanded and affordable before- and after-school childcare, like SUN programs and aftercare, to manage longer daily commutes.

To support schools receiving new students, respondents want equal facility standards across all buildings. Receiving schools should all have working air conditioning, modern playgrounds, up-to-date classroom technology, and dedicated moving funds so schools are not overwhelmed. Families also want full-time counselors, mental health services, and transition specialists to help students handle emotional stress and adjust to a new school environment.

Some community members say that no district resources can justify closing a neighborhood school. These families see district offers as temporary band-aids that fail to fix the damage caused by closures. Others worry that the district cannot maintain these supports over time, pointing to budget cuts. Finally, some respondents argue against spending money on widespread busing or transition support, insisting that all funds should go directly toward keeping teachers in classrooms.

Equity Analysis
Community members worry that the proposed changes place an unfair burden on East and Northeast Portland. They worry that historically marginalized and lower-income neighborhood schools face the majority of closures, boundary shifts, and program moves. Families point out a geographic double standard, asking why some Westside and higher-income schools remain protected while Eastside Title I and racially diverse communities bear the brunt of these disruptions.

Another major concern is the relocation and grouping of Dual Language Immersion (DLI) programs. Some families argue that moving these programs isolates students rather than integrating them into local communities. Some parents worry this move creates racial and language segregation by pulling DLI students away from their local neighborhood peers.

Respondents worry that geographic and commute challenges will create safety risks, particularly for families living east of 82nd Avenue. Students may have longer travel distances and lose access to walkable neighborhood schools. Parents are concerned about children having to cross dangerous major

streets and high-traffic corridors (e.g., 82nd Avenue, Powell Boulevard, MLK Jr. Boulevard, Fremont Street, and Broadway) without guaranteed busing or crossing guards.

For neurodivergent students and those with Individualized Education Programs (IEPs) or 504 plans, closing smaller schools creates serious disruption. Smaller environments, like K–8 schools, offer predictable daily routines and crucial sensory safety nets that help these students succeed. Removing these supportive settings and transferring students to larger, unfamiliar schools may disrupt established support structures and cause stress.

Some respondents reject the district's equity framing entirely, arguing that prioritizing demographic formulas over academic quality, safety, and school stability hurts strong programs and drives families out of the district. Others contend that true equity requires equal facility investments and high academic standards across all existing schools rather than redrawing boundaries or closing campuses.

Other Emerging Themes

A major theme across community responses is widespread distrust in district leadership. Many parents are concerned that the feedback process is just for show and that final decisions were made before public input began. To address these concerns, community members demand transparent financial data showing real cost savings compared to transition expenses, clear criteria for why specific schools were picked for closure, and updated enrollment forecasts that include new housing growth.

Working parents also express deep alarm over losing critical non-scenario programs, particularly subsidized before- and after-school childcare like SUN programs. Because school closures and boundary changes may create longer commutes, families anticipate relying on these services to keep working.

Many respondents also acknowledged that enrollment drops from lower birth rates are real and that running half-empty buildings is financially unsustainable. These respondents agree that consolidation is necessary to protect overall district funding. Additionally, some community members express frustration with pushback against every proposal, urging district leaders to act decisively and finalize rightsizing plans quickly instead of dragging out uncertainty over several years.

Emerging Questions

Community members brought forth many questions about the proposed scenarios. Common questions themes (with examples) include:

- **Selection Criteria & Geographic Equity:** e.g., "What specific, objective criteria were used to designate schools like Sellwood Middle School, Sabin, Maplewood, or James John for closure, and why do lower-enrollment Westside campuses appear protected from similar restructuring?"
- **Getting to School:** e.g., "How will students safely commute across high-speed traffic barriers—such as 82nd Avenue, SE Powell Boulevard, NE Fremont Street, or the St. Johns Bridge—without district-provided yellow bus transportation or crossing support?"
- **Financial Transparency:** e.g., "Where is the transparent financial breakdown showing net operational savings from school closures, and why hasn't central office administrative overhead been reduced prior to closing neighborhood schools?"
- **Specialized Program Relocation:** e.g., "How will relocated Dual Language Immersion (DLI) programs, K–8 configurations, and Special Education (SpEd/504) services maintain their staffing ratios and program quality when merged into larger, receiving facilities?"

- **Housing Growth vs. Enrollment Forecasting:** e.g., "How do district demographic models reconcile declining enrollment projections with active housing construction, transit-oriented apartment developments, and affordable housing infill across East and NE Portland?"
- **Transition Timelines & Grandfathering Rules:** e.g., "Will current 5th and 8th-grade students be grandfathered into their existing middle or high school feeder paths, and will sibling attendance policies be guaranteed at receiving schools?"

Last Week in Community Engagement
This past week, PPS hosted the following events:

- Board of Education School Board Meeting (October 6th)
- Board of Education Community Connection (October 9th)

After Rightsizing Scenarios were released on October 5th, the Rightsizing leadership team walked the board and the public through the details of each during the Board meeting on 10/6.

There are two main ways to share your feedback on the Rightsizing Scenarios in Portland Public Schools.

1. Complete the official Rightsizing Scenario Feedback Survey, available in English, Simplified Chinese, Somali, Spanish, Russian, and Vietnamese!
2. Attend an Engagement Event hosted by the Department of Family and Community Engagement.

For more information on how to get involved, please visit pps.net/rightsizing or email rightsizing@pps.net.

Appendix A

Count of Responses By School to Date. ***Note****: Some respondents represent multiple school communities*

School Name	**Total Respondents**
Abernethy E.S.	15
ACCESS K-8	22
Ainsworth E.S.	5
Alameda E.S.	20
Alliance	7
Arleta E.S.	9
Astor K-8	12
Atkinson E.S.	32
Beach E.S.	16
Beaumont M.S.	22
Benson Polytechnic H.S.	19
Beverly Cleary K-8	33
Boise-Eliot/Humboldt E.S.	6
Brentwood M.S.	8
Bridger Creative Science School	17
Bridlemile E.S.	14
Buckman E.S.	17
Capitol Hill E.S.	10
Cesar Chavez K-8	5
Chapman E.S.	2
Chief Joseph E.S.	8
Clark E.S.	2
Cleveland H.S.	78
Creston E.S.	30
DaVinci Arts M.S.	19
Dr Martin Luther King Jr E.S.	9
Duniway E.S.	63
Faubion PK-8	14
Forest Park E.S.	8

Franklin H.S.	37
George M.S.	19
Glencoe E.S.	8
Grant H.S.	58
Grout E.S.	8
Harriet Tubman M.S.	14
Harrison Park M.S.	15
Hayhurst E.S.	9
Hosford M.S.	27
Ida B Wells-Barnett H.S.	32
Irvington E.S.	30
Jackson M.S.	39
James John E.S.	91
Jefferson H.S.	15
Kellogg M.S.	13
Kelly E.S.	1
Laurelhurst K-8	30
Lent E.S.	1
Leodis V McDaniel H.S.	18
Lewis E.S.	50
Lincoln H.S.	28
Llewellyn E.S.	74
Maplewood E.S.	83
Markham E.S.	10
Marysville E.S.	14
Metropolitan Learning Center	13
Mt Tabor M.S.	10
Ockley Green M.S.	18
Odyssey Program K-8	8
Peninsula E.S.	26
Pioneer	6
Reconnection Center	1

Richmond E.S.	9
Rieke E.S.	7
Rigler E.S.	9
Robert Gray M.S.	10
Roosevelt H.S.	28
Rosa Parks E.S.	3
Rose City Park E.S.	48
Roseway Heights M.S.	21
Sabin E.S.	27
Scott E.S.	23
Sellwood M.S.	165
Sitton E.S.	43
Skyline K-8	15
Stephenson E.S.	57
Sunnyside Environmental K-8	75
Sunrise E.S.	1
Vernon K-8	24
Vestal E.S.	3
West Sylvan M.S.	13
Whitman E.S.	8
Winterhaven K-8	8
Woodlawn E.S.	7
Woodmere E.S.	11
Woodstock E.S.	26
Grand Total	**1969**